Savarkar now set out to wage his own war of independence, based on a vision of India as a Hindu nation made up of a Hindu race and a Hindu culture, as set out in his *Essentials of Hindutva* – written in 1923 in the penal colony of the Andaman Islands while serving out one of his many extended jail sentences – later republished as *Hindutva: Who is a Hindu?* Savarkar had as many critics as followers, then as now, but it is often forgotten that his uncompromising Hindu nationalism was equally uncompromising on the injustice of untouchability, which he regarded as a great blot on Hindu history, arguing that its eradication was essential for Hindu unity: 'To regard our 70 million co-religionists as "untouchables" and worse than animals is an insult not only to humanity but also to the sanctity of our soul ... Untouchability should be eradicated not only because it is incumbent on us but because it is impossible to justify this inhuman custom when we consider any aspect of *dharma*.'[18]

The revelation of Harappa made it possible for Savarkar and his disciples to present the Indo-European origins of the Arya and their migration into India as a colonial plot, a fiction created by the colonial British to claim family ties between Indians and Europeans. One of the first proponents of this argument was another Maharashtrian, M. S. Golwalkar. In the 1930s this university-educated *sanyasi* rose to become head of the pro-Hindu and anti-Muslim political party Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, or 'National Volunteer Organisation', better known as the RSS. 'We Hindus,' he proclaimed, 'have been in undisputed and undisturbed possession of this land for over 8 or even 10 thousand years before the land was invaded by any foreign race.'[19]

That this sectarian view of Indian history did not catch on is largely because of the determination of two secularist politicians at opposite ends of the social scale: the Old